system will stop him from doing so.

The issue of the status of the spiritual leader also poses a difficult dilemma for Western decision makers. Two approaches can be found among the Iranian spiritual leadership. Khamenei's view is that the spiritual leader is the sole decision maker. He is infallible and speaks the word of God. The view of Grand Ayatollah Hossein Ali Montazeri is that the spiritual leader's role is to make recommendations and act as a consultant, not to be the sole decision maker.

In trying to assess what the future holds, one cannot refrain from quoting Khamenei's remarks to a foreign critic: "My mission on earth is to bring about the destruction of the State of Israel, and a nuclear Iran is a tool designed to impose the will of God and Islamize the world."

Russia: Playing the Iran Card in Order to Regain Its Superpower Status

From the October Revolution in Tsarist Russia in 1917 and until the Khomeini revolution in Iran in 1979, there was hostility between the Soviet Union and Iran. In his time, Stalin encouraged the establishment of a communist party in Iran that would lead to increased Soviet influence and neutralize Western influences. The Soviet Union adopted a policy of "realpolitik" toward Iran, which had some successes here and there. But apart from the period of the Marxist republic of the Tudeh Party in northern Iran between 1942 and 1947, supported by the Soviet Union, and the period of Prime Minister Mossadegh (1951–53), who overthrew the shah and enjoyed Soviet support, Iran was a consistent ally of the United States.

The Khomeini revolution in 1979 was initially supported by the Soviets, but this changed in the wake of a series of developments:

- The Soviets were disappointed by Iran's choice to be independent of any superpower.
- Iran displayed a negative attitude toward communist atheism.
- The Soviets were miffed by Iran's support for the Mujahidin in Afghanistan in their war against the Soviet invasion of their country.
- Iran was affronted by the Soviet Union's coercive policy regarding oil prices.